



gaming and image editing, the degree of symmetry that they afford—making things easy for both right-handed and left-handed people—both on a surface and with the palm. The placement of buttons and design aspects, the quality and stability of the buttons, and the length of the cable are other critical features. Optical mice are fairly common these days, and are preferred over ball mice. In terms of interface, those that plug into the USB port should be chosen instead of PS/2 mice.

Current market analysis shows that the two-button scroll mouse is still selling more than any other type of mouse. Of late, optical mice from vendors such as Mercury and The Best can be bought for anywhere between Rs 700 and Rs 1,000. They are thus becoming more affordable, but mass acceptance is still another price-cut away, especially when a normal ball mouse can be had for less than Rs 400. The professional user would of course like the reduced hassle and the greater accuracy afforded by these optical devices.

A keyboard and mouse combination is meant to be a one-stop solution for discerning and wallet-heavy users. These bundles are

ergonomic, good to look at, and fall within the price bracket of Rs 3,500 to Rs 6,500. Some of these boards—such as Logitech's Freedom Optical—aim to offer a complete solution: in this case, a wireless, optical one.

Joysticks form an important component in the buying list of any avid gamer. The Indian market has some of the best joysticks in the world. A glut of low-priced sticks storms the arena every few months, and then vanishes off the shelf at the same speed. Major players are Microsoft and Logitech, with awesome technologies and prices to match. Companies such as Saitek, Frontech and Typhoon provide a price to performance advantage.

Features that make a difference between good and bad joysticks are force feedback, number of axes, the presence of a hat-switch, a push throttle and the number of programmable buttons. Comfort is also of paramount importance when judging the usability of a joystick.

As far as the button quality is concerned, consider the play the button offers—the less the play, the more sturdy it is. For overall finish, look for panel gaps and squeaking sounds that are usually present in a bad quality product. In terms of interface, USB joysticks should always be preferred over ones that plug into the gameport. However, make sure your PC has a free USB port before you buy one.

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Power Tips

- Adjust the height of the chair until your forearms are parallel to the keyboard when typing, and your wrists are in a neutral position.
- Ensure your eyes are at the same height as the top of the monitor.
- Keep the keyboard and mouse close to you to avoid stretching to reach these devices.
- Leave space in front of the keyboard for you to rest your hands when you are not using the keyboard.
- Keep the screen and keyboard in a position that's best suited for your task. They could be directly in front of you or slightly to one side.
- Maintain a good posture when working at the keyboard. You can avoid back pain by using a chair that offers back support.
- Keep your shoulders relaxed, with your elbows close to your sides, when working.
- Avoid resting your elbows on the hard sur-



face or edge of your table.

- Pads can be used to protect your elbows if necessary.
- Avoid hitting the keys on the keyboard with excessive force.
- Avoid holding the mouse tightly.
- Take frequent breaks from typing.
- When typing, keep hands relaxed and fingers gently curved. Your hands should 'float' easily above the keyboard.
- Allow wrists to rest on a wrist pad during preparation for next entry, not when typing. Avoid extended wrist positions.
- Try a different keyboard, mice and trackball. There are many designs available in the market and you should find one that works best for you. If you find a mouse uncomfortable, you could try switching to a trackball.